

INDIVIDUAL ASSIGNMENT-2

Reflection Paper/Synopsis

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In this individual assignment, I reviewed five listed companies from different industries; City Bank (banking), Grameenphone (telecom), BAT Bangladesh (FMCG/tobacco), LafargeHolcim Bangladesh (cement/building materials) and Beximco Pharma (pharmaceuticals). The main purpose was to understand how different businesses report performance, manage risks and communicate value creation to shareholders through their annual reports. Overall, I realized that although the industries are very different, the reports follow a similar “story”: (1) performance results, (2) strategy, (3) governance and risk management and (4) sustainability/long-term outlook.

A major learning for me is how “performance” depends heavily on industry structure. For example, Grameenphone’s report shows that telecom is driven by scale and continuous investment; network modernization, digital channels like MyGP and customer experience improvements. Even when revenue growth is small, the company can still remain profitable due to its strong market position and cash generation ability. In contrast, LafargeHolcim’s report highlights that cement is very sensitive to external costs like energy and imported input prices; therefore, operational efficiency (such as using alternative fuels and improving energy efficiency) becomes a key survival and performance factor. So, one clear takeaway is: telecom performance is more scale-and-investment driven, while cement performance is more cost-and-macro driven.

From the banking side, City Bank’s annual report made me understand how trust and stability become competitive advantages during sector stress. The report strongly emphasizes deposit growth, liquidity strength and conservative risk management (NPL control and strong provisioning coverage). It also shows that banks do not only “sell products”; they manage risk as a core business. So, profitability in banking is tightly connected with asset quality and risk governance. One thing I found interesting is that City Bank also connects its future growth with digital transformation, showing how digital banking is becoming a strategic driver in financial services.

BAT Bangladesh’s report showed a different style compared to the others. It heavily focuses on governance, sustainability and its national contribution (tax and exchequer contribution). From my understanding, this is because tobacco is a heavily regulated

industry and public perception matters. Their risks are mainly policy-related; tax changes, regulation and illicit trade; so the report tries to justify legitimacy and compliance while still communicating strong profitability and consistent shareholder returns (dividend). This helped me realize that annual reports are not only financial documents; they are also “reputation management” tools depending on industry sensitivity.

For Beximco Pharma, the report shows how pharma growth is linked to export expansion, product pipeline and regulatory approvals (especially in regulated markets). This industry is more about compliance, quality and innovation; because without approvals and strict quality standards, export growth is not possible. Compared to cement or telecom, pharma risks are more related to FX exposure (imports and exports), regulatory compliance, and financial pressures (like debt/finance cost). So, I learned that pharma companies must balance both commercial goals (market expansion) and strict compliance requirements at the same time.

Across all five reports, the most common repeated themes were dividend policy, risk disclosures, and sustainability/ESG reporting. Grameenphone and BAT Bangladesh highlight consistent dividend patterns, showing that stable cash returns are a big part of shareholder value in mature industries. City Bank shows a more balanced shareholder return approach (cash + stock dividend), which makes sense because banks also need to manage capital adequacy and future lending growth. LafargeHolcim’s report shows dividend is tied to performance and policy decisions (interim vs final) and it reflects how cyclical and cost pressure can impact shareholder payout decisions. Overall, I learned that dividend decisions are not random; they are linked to industry stability, cash generation ability, and risk outlook.